

621 kg of waste a head, 74% landfilled?

*Testing the European Commission's 2026 Country Report
against the Eurostat data it cites*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Over the last 10 years, Malta has brought its landfill rate down from 82% to 74%. However, this is still one of the highest in the EU.”

European Commission, 2026 Country Report – Malta, 3 June 2026.

Annex 8, alongside “621 kg per person generated in 2024 (compared with the EU average of 517 kg)”.

VERDICT: SUPPORTED

Every figure reproduces from Eurostat env_wasmun

Version 1.0 · 5 October 2026

Status: no right of reply needed

Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

In its 2026 Country Report on Malta (3 June 2026), the European Commission wrote that “**waste generation is still high with 621 kg per person generated in 2024 (compared with the EU average of 517 kg per person)**”, and that “**over the last 10 years, Malta has brought its landfill rate down from 82% to 74%. However, this is still one of the highest in the EU, and well above the EU average of 22% (2023).**” We re-ran the figures from the Eurostat dataset the report cites.

- 1

The waste figures are right. Eurostat env_wasmun gives 621 kg of municipal waste per person in Malta in 2024 and 517 kg for the EU-27 (provisional). Malta is 20% above the EU average and sixth-highest of the 20 states with 2024 data.
- 2

The landfill figures are right, on the basis the report uses. Landfilled waste as a share of waste generated was 82.0% in 2013 and 73.6% in 2023. Malta had the third-highest rate in 2023 (after Greece and Romania) and the highest of the states reporting for 2024 (72.1%).
- 3

“Down from 82% to 74%” is mostly one year. The rate stayed between 76% and 91% from 2013 to 2022 and fell from 83% to 74% between 2022 and 2023. The Commission’s own summary elsewhere in the report calls this “only a marginal drop in the last decade”.
- 4

Different sources, different landfill shares. Measured against waste *treated* rather than generated, the same 2024 data give 79.2%: this is the figure The Shift reported (CC-081). Both are correct; they answer different questions.
- 5

Verdict: supported (high confidence). Every number in the passage reproduces from the cited Eurostat data. The EU-27 landfill rate for 2023 is not published in the dataset; the 2022 and 2024 values (22.6% and 21.3%) bracket the report’s 22%.

THIS CLAIM

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

621 kg

Municipal waste per person in Malta, 2024 (EU 517 kg)

74%

Share of municipal waste landfilled in 2023 (EU about 22%)

3rd

Malta’s rank for landfill rate in 2023; 1st of 20 states with 2024 data

72%

Malta’s landfill rate in 2024, the year after the report’s figure

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

None: Supported is the top of the scale.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

A revision of the Eurostat data showing different values, or evidence that the 82% and 74% were calculated on different bases.

IN THIS REPORT

1 The claim and what we could verify

2 Method

3 What the data show

4 Where the evidence points different ways

5 Testing the claim

6 Verdict and requests for evidence

7 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The 2026 Country Report for Malta is a Commission staff working document (SWD(2026) 218 final) published with the European Semester spring package and transmitted to the Council as document 10135/26 ADD 1 [1]. We read the Council copy in full on 5 October 2026. The waste passage is in Annex 8 (“Competitiveness and the green transition”, page 75), with footnotes (156) and (158) citing Eurostat’s municipal waste dataset [2]. The same figures appear in the report’s summary (pages 17–18), which adds the recycling rate (16.7% in 2024, EU 48%) and the 2035 landfill target of 10%.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
European Commission, 2026 Country Report – Malta, Annex 8 [1]	“Waste generation is still high with 621 kg per person generated in 2024 (compared with the EU average of 517 kg per person)” ... “Over the last 10 years, Malta has brought its landfill rate down from 82% to 74%. However, this is still one of the highest in the EU, and well above the EU average of 22% (2023).”	Full text read (Council PDF), 5 Oct 2026.	The claim
European Commission, same report, summary (pp. 17–18) [1]	Same figures; “the municipal waste landfill rate recorded only a marginal drop in the last decade and is still high at 74% in 2023”.	Read.	Context
Eurostat, env_wasmun [2]	Municipal waste generated and treated, by operation, kg per person.	Downloaded 5 Oct 2026 (data/cc-111/).	Primary data
The Shift, Feb 2026 (CC-081) [3]	79.2% of Malta’s municipal waste landfilled in 2024.	Claim record of CC-081.	Context

2 Method

Question. Do the figures in the passage reproduce from the data the report cites, and is the comparison with other member states right?

Evidence. We downloaded env_wasmun (updated 30 March 2026) for Malta and the EU-27, 2012–2024, and for every member state for 2023–2024 (*tools/cc-111-report/fetch.py*), and recomputed each figure with a script (*calc.py*; outputs in *data/cc-111/checks.csv*). The “landfill rate” is landfill and other disposal (operations D1–D7 and D12) divided by waste generated, the basis that reproduces both of the report’s Malta figures; we also give the share of waste treated. The EU-27 total for 2024 carries Eurostat’s flag “i” (see metadata); Malta’s values carry no flags.

Grades. Official statistics are grade C in our scale. The claim is a statistical statement; we used no peer-reviewed literature because none is needed to test it. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the data show

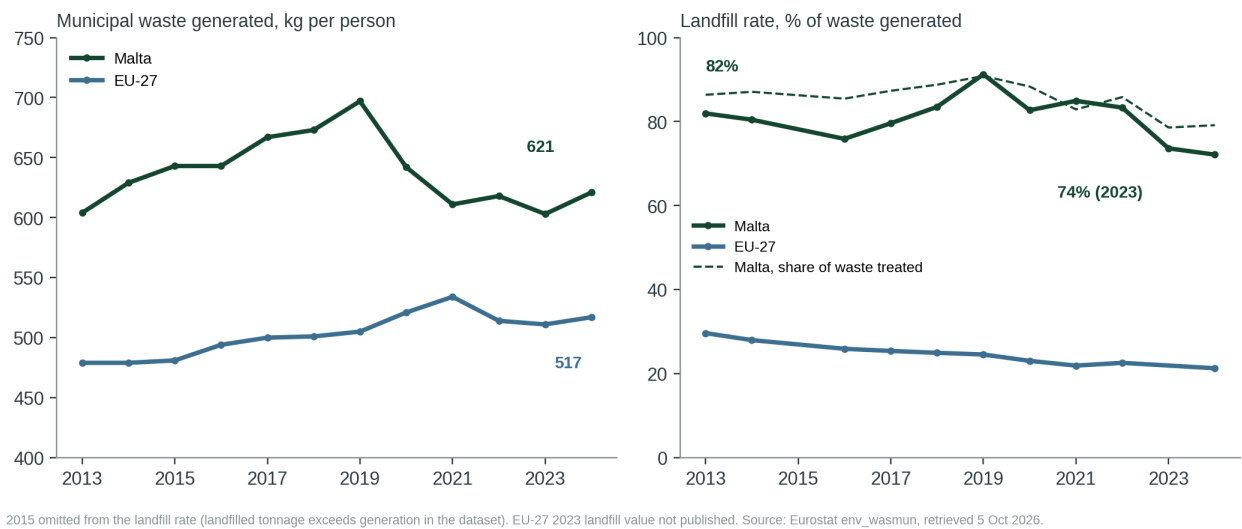


Figure 1. Municipal waste per person (left) and the share landfilled (right), Malta and the EU-27, 2013–2024. The dashed line is Malta’s landfilled waste as a share of waste treated.

Malta generated 621 kg of municipal waste per person in 2024, up from 603 kg in 2023; the EU-27 figure is 517 kg. Malta’s figure peaked at 697 kg in 2019. Landfilled waste was 82.0% of waste generated in 2013 and 73.6% in 2023; in 2024 it was 72.1%. Incineration was 2.7% of waste generated in 2023, matching the report’s “3%”.

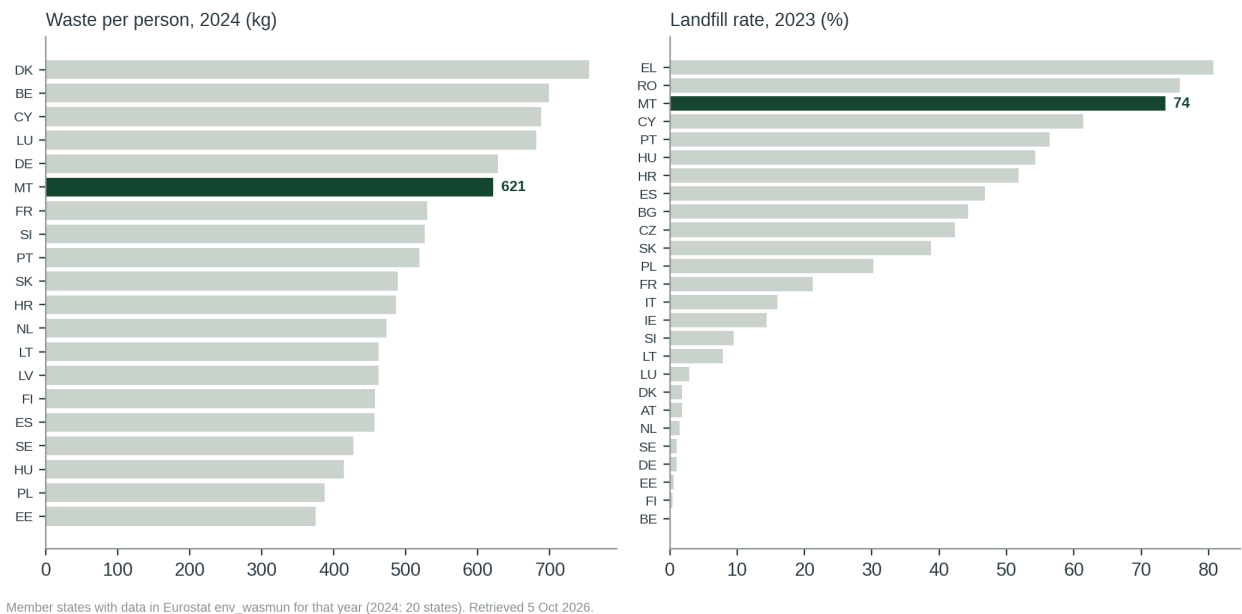


Figure 2. Malta among the member states with data: sixth-highest for waste per person in 2024 and third-highest for the landfill rate in 2023.

4

Where the evidence points different ways

Which landfill share is right: 74%, 72% or 79%?

ALL, ON THEIR OWN BASIS

THE REPORT'S BASIS

The report's 82% and 74% are landfilled waste as a share of waste generated, for 2013 and 2023. On that basis the 2024 figure is 72.1%.

OTHER BASES

The Shift (CC-081) reported 79.2% for 2024: landfilled waste as a share of waste treated. Malta treats less waste than it generates in most years (566 kg treated against 621 kg generated in 2024), so the two shares differ. The National Statistics Office uses its own definitions.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

No contradiction: the figures measure different things. A reader comparing sources should check which denominator is used.

Is a fall from 82% to 74% “over the last 10 years” a fair description?

ACCURATE, BUT LUMPY

FOR

The endpoints are right: 82.0% in 2013 and 73.6% in 2023.

CAVEAT

The fall happened in one step: the rate was 83.3% in 2022. Between 2013 and 2022 it ranged from 76% to 91%. The report's summary describes the decade as “only a marginal drop”.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

The sentence is accurate. It does not describe a steady trend, and the report does not claim one.

5

Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. 621 kg of waste per person in 2024, against an EU average of 517 kg	Commission [1]	Eurostat env_wasmun: Malta 621 kg, EU-27 517 kg (provisional). Malta is sixth-highest of 20 states with 2024 data.	ACCURATE
B. Landfill rate down from 82% to 74% over ten years	Commission [1]	82.0% (2013) and 73.6% (2023), landfilled as a share of generated. Most of the fall came in 2023.	ACCURATE
C. Still one of the highest in the EU, well above the EU average of 22% (2023)	Commission [1]	Third-highest in 2023 (after Greece and Romania); highest of 20 states in 2024. EU-27 2023 not published; 22.6% in 2022 and 21.3% in 2024.	ACCURATE

6

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

SUPPORTED

Every figure in the passage reproduces from the Eurostat data the report cites. Confidence: high.

Why. The per-person figures (621 kg, 517 kg), the landfill rates (82%, 74%), the incineration rate (3%) and Malta's position among member states all reproduce from env_wasmun on the basis the report uses. The one figure we cannot reproduce exactly, the EU-27 landfill rate for 2023, is not in the dataset, but the neighbouring years agree with it.

What this verdict does not say. It does not rate Malta’s waste policy. The Ministry’s claim of “strong progress” on recycling is checked separately (CC-004), and the landfill shares reported by other outlets are not wrong because they differ from this one.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From Eurostat: the EU-27 landfill rate for 2023, which env_wasmun does not yet publish.
- ☐ From Malta’s waste authorities: an explanation of the 2015 values, when landfilled municipal waste (676 kg per person) exceeds waste generated (643 kg).

RIGHT OF REPLY

Not needed for this verdict (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026: a reply is sought only for *Not substantiated*, *Misleading* or *Contradicted*).

7

Limitations

- The EU-27 total for 2024 is flagged by Eurostat; 2024 data are missing for seven member states, so the 2024 ranking covers 20 states.
- Municipal waste statistics depend on national reporting; definitions of municipal waste and of treatment differ between countries and over time.
- We did not test the summary’s recycling figures (16.7%, EU 48%) or the 2035 target; the recycling question is checked in CC-004.
- We read the report in its Council copy; the Commission’s own publication should be identical.

References

- [1] European Commission (3 June 2026). 2026 Country Report – Malta. SWD(2026) 218 final; Council document 10135/26 ADD 1. Annex 8, p. 75, and summary, pp. 17–18. <https://data.consilium.europa.eu/doc/document/ST-10135-2026-ADD-1/en/pdf>
- [2] Eurostat. Municipal waste by waste management operations (env_wasmun), updated 30 Mar 2026, retrieved 5 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/env_wasmun/default/table
- [3] MiŽien. CC-081 claim record (The Shift, landfill share rising) and CC-004 report (recycling): claims/CC-081, claims/CC-004.
- [4] MiŽien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-111-report/calc.py; data/cc-111/checks.csv.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	5 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Supported (high confidence); no right of reply needed.